Forged in Flames (Of Embarrassment)

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by ManInTheBlueSuit

Summary

Catra and Adora have an epic tale for the ages: from nemesises, to partners, to their happily-ever-after has been a long and challenging road. But there are other journeys far less troublesome, yet still just as gruelling in their own ways.

(OR)

The GlimBow side-story, featuring the talented Princess_Cyra and her beau.

Life had been blissful for five years. Finn was erratically running around school now, and Perfuma and Scorpia had arranged rotating school runs to prevent any recurrences of the unfortunate incident where Finn had complained to his moms about the new kid being mean in class. Their excuses that they'd just come from a sparring match and that swords shouldn't be left unattended had not prevented the school from raising stern objections to their continued presence on school grounds. However, they also agreed to deal with the new student and ensure he stopped being a nuisance. Catra's smile only made the principal nervous enough to accept suspending the new kid for a few days while she ask the other pupils how much of a disruption he had been being. Adora simply stared until they received promises that additional safeguards would be put in place to ensure minimal disruption.

"You know you didn't need to push any further," Catra pointed out as they finally left the terrified administrator. "We already had them handling the kid."

"I wasn't pushing," Adora grumbled, fondling the pommel of her weapon. "I was thinking if there was anything else we needed to discuss."

"Nope!" Finn said a bit too quickly for their liking.

Catra glanced knowingly at her wife. "Everything's going okay then?" She asked.

"Yep." Finn ducked between them, hiding from eyeline.

"No other problem children we need to talk about?" Adora probed.

"Nope." Said the problem child.

"Hmm," Catra's eyes narrowed. "Homework all done?"

"..."

Busted! "Well," She smiled understandingly. "I think we'll sit down tonight and go over it together. If you and your momma can't do it, I'm sure I can lend a hand."

"Hey!" Catra cackled, swooping Finn into her arms with cackling glee.

"Don't worry," She grinned. "We can always set Entrapta on their curriculum if it's garbage." Finn was the golden-haired child of two intense ladies, and the nibling of five *extremely* doting godparents. If they put their heads together, they might be able to pinpoint a week where Finn hadn't seen at least one of them. Through Glimmer, they even had some adoring grand-godparents in Micah and Angella. Perfuma was endlessly supportive, encouraging Finn's artistic and emotional expressive sides. Bow and Scorpia had continued their watery feud, inducting a new member in their ongoing battles. Finn was learning a lot about nutrition and cooking as a result, but was confused why they were fighting about different types of water when juice was the best.

Bow and Glimmer had come over for a quiet evening. They'd spent plenty of time happily playing with Finn; Glimmer treating Finn's play with the enjoyment it deserved, Bow happily examining every decision through a lens of scientific integrity. He'd been heartbroken when Glimmer was crowned the most favourite Queen, but accepted his position as 'Professor Doctor' Bow with suitable aplomb.

Eventually, with Finn nodding off and insisting they weren't tired, the adults had ushered the sleepy child to bed, promising they wouldn't have any fun without them.

Being boring adults, they did what boring adults did best - opened a bottle of mid-range wine, put on some lamps, and engaged full effort into chilling out.

Adora took the opening gambit, asking Bow "How's business?" Bow and Scorpia's rivalry had progressed to such an extent that they'd decided the only way for a fair fight was a frank and equal

battlefield. It was unusual, and there had been some concern that maybe mixing business into a personal relationship would destabilise the entire affair but the pair were holding together well enough. They'd handed the logistical work over to Entrapta, who cared only for the data, and her new partner. Hordak had a coarse and abrasive attitude but there was no arguing with the results he generated.

"Good," Bow sipped from his glass. "I'm currently a couple of points behind, but Scorpia insists that my gadgets should be included but she's the one working the gym all the time." With their water formulas now a company secret, and being mass produced, Bow had branched out into making sports gadgets, and Scorpia had opened a gym that was rapidly expanding into a full business enterprise. Though she'd intended for it to be called the 'Fight Zone', her clumsy handwriting had accidentally caused the business name to become the 'Fright Zone'. A lot of customers had been perturbed at word of the heavy hitting boxer who ran the place, but had quickly learned to love the behemoth with a heart of gold.

"Doesn't it freak you out that Bow and Scorpia spend so much time together?" Catra asked Glimmer with a wry smile. Truthfully, nobody in their close circle of friends cared who spent time with who. They could probably walk into a room to see Bow down on one knee, presenting a ring to Scorpia and nobody would bat an eye.

"Not at all," Glimmer grinned. "Worst case, he makes a move and I tell Perfuma - I hear her flowers could always do with good fertiliser." They shared a laugh at that. When she wasn't running community gardens, Perfuma was running support groups and had plenty of thorns to match her flowers. "Plus, we've been together a while, I think he'd have tried something by now if he was bored."

"Hey," Adora grinned in a way that made her wife proud as she glanced at her. "Have you ever heard the story of how Glimmer met Bow's parents?"

Glimmer choked on her drink, spluttering as she put her glass on the table. "Don't you dare!" She glared.

"Oh?" Catra raised an eyebrow. "I've never known you to get like this. Something I should know about, Sparkles?" Glimmer glared as Catra smirked over a slow sip of wine.

"This was back," Adora began.

"**No!**" Glimmer snapped with unusual aggression. "You *always* get it wrong."

"What do I get wrong, exactly?" Adora smiled too innocently to not be complicit.

Bow glanced at Catra, recognising her influence. The look Catra sent back said how proud she was of her wife, and it was nice that she was learning how to politely push a point. Bow rolled his eyes in acceptance, recognising that Adora did have a habit of trying too hard to appeal to the moral qualities of a person instead of the moral or practical ones. The entire conversation took a couple of seconds, by which Glimmer was begrudgingly starting her story.

"It's nothing *novel worthy*," She twisted the words like a knife. It might have worked had her target not been used to swords. "So, back when we were in school, I was going to borrow some books from Bow. I'd had a sleepover the night before, and a couple of the meddling pookas that I called my 'friends' decided to invite themselves along."

"Of course." Adora gravely agreed. It was always important to follow your friends to potentially embarrassing situations.

"I left with these two, Frosta and Mermista. Frosta was navigating because she was always on her phone anyway. Mermista hadn't even gotten out of her pyjamas and was dragging her feet. Bow didn't live as close to me back then,"

"I'll say." Catra smirked, earning an elbow dig from her wife. There was a time and place.

"We took a while to get there," Glimmer ignored the interruption. "And then I tried to get into the stairs that led to his place but it was locked. And I tried to figure out the passcode, but I couldn't remember what Bow had told me."

"I *said* to use the intercom to let me know that she'd arrived," Bow smiled knowingly. "Because it was locked."

"Shush," Glimmer clumsily covered his mouth as he fought back. "*I'm* telling the story," Bow surrendered and let her take over. "I'd left my phone at home, and *nobody* remembers numbers anymore. But I did remember my mom's number, so I borrowed Frosta's phone to call her. *Three times!*" She spread her fingers to highlight the cost. "**Three times**, I called her, and she didn't pick up. While she's busy not answering the phone, I'm starting to feel like a creep hanging out in the parking lot, so I call my dad to send Frosta Bow's number. My friends are waiting around outside because I'd asked them not to leave in case I couldn't get up, and are starting to look at me like I'm a crazy stalker."

"I've been there." Catra smirked at her wife.

"Nemesis," Adora stressed. "Why is it so hard for you people to understand that it's normal to study your opponent?" She stubbornly repeated the losing argument to her friends.

"Study, yes, fixate over, no." Catra argued. "You two knew her back then, what did you think?"

"Concerned." Glimmer shrugged.

"Unnerving." Bow agreed.

"Traitors." Adora glared. "And you were explaining how you completely forgot how to find your future husband's apartment?"

Glimmer glared but continued. "*Finally*, I had his number, so I called him."

"She was so *cute*," Bow squealed, wrapping both arms around Glimmer and pulling her close. "Sounding all nervous and guilty. She asked me to come and get her."

"He gave me the code for the door *again* and made me practice in front of him before we went up. I met his dad, Lance, and one of his brothers. They were playing with robot vacuum cleaners, and I made small talk while Bow fetched the textbooks he promised until I could politely take my leave. But then Lance asked if I wanted to stay for a bit. Three guesses what I said," She glumly reached for her glass and took a fortifying drink.

"I have to go, my phone's dead?" Catra offered.

"My friends are waiting downstairs, I should go and find them," Glimmer covered her face in shame as the others waited for the punchline. "My friends who *explicitly* said to stay upstairs if I was invited." The laughter came, right on cue. "Trust me, it's more embarrassing for me, okay?" Glimmer mumbled. "Bow starts walking me downstairs, rambling about some 3D thing to go downstairs in his D&D stuff,"

"D20." Adora corrected without thinking. Then she caught the looks coming her way. "Oh no."

"Heh," Catra smiled lovingly. "*Nerd.*" She said the name as affectionately as any term of endearment.

"What race?" Bow raised a brow.

"Orc." Adora sighed. "You?"

"*Gnome.*" He sounded offended by the question.

"Hey!" Catra warned. "We're embarrassing *your* wife, mine can wait."

"Okay, *wow*," Glimmer scowled. "But fine; Bow took me downstairs, and *that's* when he found out that Mermista and Frosta were circling the building like razor-fins, trying to catch a glimpse of Bow because they hadn't seen a good photo of him before."

"We walked *right* into them," Bow laughed. "I've never seen Mermista look that shocked - or that *anything*!"

"We all said 'hi' to each other, it was *awkward*, and then I went home." Glimmer turtled down into her sweater and pulled a cushion onto her head. "I hate myself - this is worse than the first time Bow asked me to lunch!"

"It was for a lovely cafe beside the beach, overlooking the ocean," Bow explained. "And Glimmer says 'no' because,"

"Because the sand would get in our food!" She groaned.

"I'm starting to think we both married idiots." Catra remarked to Bow.

"More like 'all'," Bow laughed unashamedly. "I didn't even know that Glimmer and I were dating for the first six months!" The four spouses looked at each other in tense silence, and then burst out laughing.

"We're all helpless!" Glimmer admitted between gasps.

"How did you not know she liked you?" Adora wheezed.

"How did you not know that *you* liked *me*?" Catra gripped her chest as she struggled to suck in enough air.

"There were so many signs," Bow agreed. "Like the hate board."

"The phone."

"The stalk of the town!" Bow abruptly changed words midway as he glanced at the door. All eyes looked over to see Finn standing

in the doorway, rubbing a tiny eye.

"Sweetie, what are you doing up?" Adora asked gently. "I thought you went to bed."

"Couldn't sleep," Finn mumbled rebelliously. "You said you wouldn't have fun without me." They pouted.

"I'm sorry, I promise we didn't mean to." Catra apologised, passing Adora her wine glass and opening both arms. Finn toddled across, clambering up to sit on her lap.

"We were talking about Auntie Scorpia and Uncle Bow's business when Auntie Glimmer started telling us the story of how she met Uncle Bow." Adora explained, setting both their glasses aside. "It was such a funny story that we couldn't help laughing."

"Funny story?" Finn eagerly seized on the important information. "Can I hear it?" Tiny little eyes stared adoringly out at Glimmer.

"Well, I," She stammered for an excuse.

"I'm sure Auntie Glimmer wouldn't mind telling it just *one* more time." Catra grinned, nestling around her undeniable child.

"But straight to bed afterwards," Adora moved along as if her old friend had already agreed. "You need to get your rest."

"Okay," Finn agreed excitedly. Permission to stay up late? This never happened before, and any price was worth paying! "One story, then bed!"

'Traitors' Glimmer thought silently to herself as she glared at the pair.

"Should I tell it this time?" Bow offered.

"No, it's alright," Glimmer sighed, fixing Finn with a weary smile. "You know I tell it better." And then, she began.

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